The Scarlet Letter

By Nathaniel Hawthorne

The grass-plot before the jail, in Prison Lane, was occupied by a large number of the inhabitants of Boston; all with their eyes intently fastened on the iron-clamped oaken door. It might be that an undutiful child, whom his parents had given over to the civil authority, was to be corrected at the whipping-post. It might be, too, that a witch, was to die upon the gallows. The women appeared to take a peculiar interest in whatever penal infliction might be expected to ensue.

INTRODUCTION

Set in colonial New England, Hester Prynne has come to Boston ahead of her husband. When she gives birth to a daughter, the time-line just doesn't match up and it becomes obvious that she has committed adultery. The community's response – Public Shaming.

We've come a long way since then . . . or have we? In an age of cyber-bullying and demagoging politicians, this practice lives on. We still live in a Scarlet Letter Society. Look at the most recent headlines: [insert your own examples here to keep this intro up to date] A President

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impeached as a result of alleged infidelity; A high-school student attacked for disrespecting a Native American during a protest rally in Washington DC . . . the list goes on. We don't sew scarlet letters on the clothing of the immoral transgressors anymore. Instead we flash their images around the world from televisions and computer screens.

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WOMAN 1: Goodwives, I'll tell ye a piece of my mind. If we women, being of mature age and church-members in good repute, should have the handling this Hester Prynne, what think ye, gossips? If the hussy stood up for judgment before would she come off with such a sentence as the magistrates have awarded? Marry, I trow not!

WOMAN 2: People say that the Reverend Dimmesdale, takes it very grievously to heart that such a scandal should have come upon his congregation."

WOMAN 3: The magistrates are God-fearing gentlemen, but merciful overmuch—that is a truth. At the very least, they should have put the brand of a hot iron on Hester Prynne's forehead. Little will she care

what they put upon the bodice of her gown! Why, she may cover it with a brooch, or such like, and so walk the streets as brave as ever!

WOMAN 4: (softly) Ah, but, let her cover the mark as she will, the pang of it will be always in her heart.

WOMAN 5: What do we talk of marks and brands, whether on the bodice of her gown, or the flesh of her forehead? This woman has brought shame upon us all, and ought to die. Is there not law for it? Truly there is, both in the Scripture and the statute-book. Then let the magistrates, who have made it of no effect, thank themselves if their own wives and daughters go astray!

The door of the jail being flung open from within, there appeared, the grim and grisly presence of the town-beadle. Stretching forth the official staff in his left hand, he laid his right upon the shoulder of a young woman. On the threshold of the prison-door, she repelled him and stepped into the open air, as if by her own free-will. She bore in her arms a child, a baby of

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some three months old acquainted only with the gray twilight of a dungeon.

She took the baby on her arm, and, with a burning blush, and yet a haughty smile, and a glance that would not be abashed, looked around at her neighbors. On the breast of her gown, in fine red cloth, surrounded with an elaborate embroidery and fantastic flourishes of gold thread, appeared the letter A. It was so artistically done that it had all the effect of a fitting decoration to the apparel which she wore; a splendor greatly beyond what was allowed by the regulations of the colony.

She had dark and abundant hair, so glossy that it threw off the sunshine with a gleam, and a face which, besides being beautiful, had the impressiveness belonging to deep black eyes. Never had Hester Prynne appeared more lady-like, in the antique interpretation of the term, than as she issued from the prison. Those who had expected to behold her dimmed and obscured by a disastrous cloud, were astonished to perceive how her beauty shone out, and made a halo of the misfortune in

which she was enveloped. But the point which drew all eyes, and, as it were, transfigured the wearer, was that SCARLET LETTER, so fantastically embroidered and illuminated upon her bosom. It had the effect of a spell, taking her out of the ordinary relations with humanity, and inclosing her in a sphere by herself.

WOMAN 1: She hath good skill at her needle, that's certain, but did ever a woman, before this brazen hussy, contrive such a way of showing it! Why, gossips, what is it but to laugh in the faces of our magistrates, and make a pride out of what they meant for a punishment?"

WOMAN 2: It were well if we stripped Madam Hester's rich gown off her dainty shoulders; and as for the red letter, which she hath stitched so curiously, I'll bestow a rag of mine own rheumatic flannel, to make a fitter one!

WOMAN 4: (whispering) O, peace, neighbours, peace! Do not let her hear you! Not a stitch in that embroidered letter, but she has felt it in her heart.

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BEADLE: (gesturing with his staff) Make way, good people, make way, in the King's name. Open a passage. Come along, Madam Hester, and show your scarlet letter in the market-place!

A lane was forthwith opened through the crowd of spectators. And Hester Prynne set forth towards the place appointed for her punishment. A crowd of eager and curious schoolboys, understanding little of the matter in hand, except that it gave them a half-holiday, ran before her progress, turning their heads continually to stare into her face, and at the baby in her arms, and at the letter on her breast. As haughty as her demeanor was, she perchance underwent an agony from every footstep of those that thronged to see her, as if her heart had been flung into the street for them all to spurn and trample upon. With almost a serene deportment, Hester Prynne passed through this portion of her ordeal, and came to a sort of scaffold. It stood nearly beneath the eaves of Boston's earliest church, and appeared to be a fixture there.

In fact, this scaffold constituted a portion of a penal machine – as effectual an agent in the promotion of good citizenship, as ever was the guillotine among the terrorists of France. There can be no outrage, methinks, against our common nature—whatever be the delinquencies of the individual—no outrage more flagrant than to forbid the culprit to hide his face for shame. In Hester Prynne's instance, her sentence bore, that she should stand a certain time upon the platform. Knowing well her part, she ascended a flight of wooden steps, and was thus displayed to the surrounding multitude, at about the height of a man's shoulders above the street.

Hester Prynne stood on the scaffold of the pillory, an infant on her arm, and the letter A, in scarlet, fantastically embroidered with gold thread, upon her bosom!

The scene was not without a mixture of awe, such as must always invest the spectacle of guilt and shame in a fellow-creature, before society shall have grown corrupt enough to smile, instead of shuddering, at it.

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The Governor, and several of his counsellors, a judge, a general, and the ministers of the town; sat or stood in a balcony of the meeting-house, looking down upon the platform. The crowd was sombre and grave. The unhappy culprit sustained herself as best a woman might, under the heavy weight of a thousand unrelenting eyes, all fastened upon her. It was almost intolerable to be borne. Had a roar of laughter burst from the multitude,—each man, each woman, each little shrill-voiced child, contributing their individual parts,—Hester Prynne might have repaid them all with a bitter and disdainful smile. But, under the leaden infliction which it was her doom to endure, she felt, at moments, as if she must needs shriek out with the full power of her lungs, and cast herself from the scaffold down upon the ground, or else go mad at once.

Could it be true? She clutched the child so fiercely to her breast, that it sent forth a cry; she turned her eyes downward at the scarlet letter, and even touched it with her finger, to assure herself that

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the infant and the shame were real. Yes!—these were her realities.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nathaniel Hawthorne
ISBN: 978-0553210095
Publisher: Bantam Classics
Date (Month/Year): March 1981

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